



WHAT YOU VALUE MOST

How to read a dental treatment plan

The three categories every plan contains but rarely labels, six questions that separate them, and how to get a second opinion without it being awkward.

The Straight Answer · A Dentist Fit guide · General information, not dental advice

Why this is a reasonable thing to want

Almost every treatment plan mixes three different things: work that is necessary now, work that is sensible in the next year or two, and work that is genuinely optional. They carry very different urgency and very different consequences for waiting.

The trouble is that a plan usually arrives as one list with one number at the bottom. Presented that way it is impossible to evaluate, and the reasonable response is the one you already have, which is a slight wariness about all of it.

The fix is not suspicion, it is sorting. Once each item is in a category, out loud, the conversation becomes something you can actually take part in, and a recommendation that holds up under that sorting is one you can trust.

IMAGE TO PLACE

A printed treatment plan on a desk with a pen, hands only. The artefact this guide teaches people to read.

Six questions worth asking any practice

These work on any practice. Take them with you wherever you go, including somewhere that is not us.

1 Can I have this in writing, itemised?

Every reputable practice expects this and produces it without friction. Itemised means each item priced separately, not one total.

2 Which of these is necessary now, which is sensible soon, and which is optional?

The most useful question in this guide. Ask for the three categories explicitly and watch how comfortably they are given.

3 What happens if I wait six months on this one?

Ask it item by item. A real answer sounds specific. Some things genuinely worsen on a schedule, and a dentist who says so about one item and not another is telling you they are distinguishing between them.

4 What are the alternatives, including doing nothing?

Most treatments have more than one approach at different costs and lifespans. Doing nothing is a real option with real consequences, and it should be describable.

5 What will my insurance actually cover, and what is my annual maximum?

Ask the practice to predetermine with your insurer for larger work. Also worth checking whether you qualify under the Canadian Dental Care Plan.

6 Can I have copies of my x-rays?

They are your records. Asking for them is normal and a second opinion is a routine part of medicine and dentistry, not an accusation.

A second opinion is not an insult. For anything large or irreversible, it is ordinary good practice, and most dentists will say so themselves. If asking about one makes the conversation tense, that reaction is itself a piece of information.

Signs of a plan you can trust

- The categories were named before you asked for them
- You were told plainly that something can wait
- The estimate is itemised and in writing
- Alternatives were offered, including the cheaper one
- Nobody needed a decision from you that day

IMAGE TO PLACE

Dr. Mehta talking through a written estimate with a patient, both looking at the paper.

A small practice, on purpose

Reflections is two chairs on Crowchild Trail. Dr. Ashish Mehta sees a small number of people, and that is a deliberate choice about how he wants to practise.

Telling someone a thing can wait is the part people remember, and it is easier to do in a practice that is not built around volume. Dr. Mehta would rather explain the sorting than present a number.

"I see a small number of people, and that is on purpose."

Dr. Ashish Mehta

IMAGE TO PLACE

Dr. Mehta at his desk rather than chairside, in conversation.

Ask us these too

This guide is only worth anything if it works on us as well. If you come in, put these to Dr. Mehta directly.

1 Which of these could I reasonably wait on?

The answer to this is the fastest read on whether a plan was built around you.

2 What would you do if this were your mouth?

A fair question, and most dentists answer it honestly when asked directly.

3 Will you put the categories in writing with the estimate?

If the sorting is real, it survives being written down.

Thirty minutes, free, no treatment

Bring a treatment plan from anywhere, including somewhere else, and Dr. Mehta will walk you through how to read it. Thirty minutes, no treatment, no cost, and no expectation that you become a patient.

Book your free 30 minutes

4600 Crowchild Trail NW, Suite 505, Calgary · (587) 327-8651
Nothing is done to your teeth at this visit, and there is no cost.

This guide is general information about choosing dental care. It is not dental advice, it is not a diagnosis, and it is not a comment on any other practice. The questions in it are worth asking of any dentist, including this one. Your own dentist knows your mouth and your history, and nothing here replaces that. Reflections Dental Group, Calgary, Alberta.